

For Xhenis and
Petru, because how
they XPerience
love and life with
fierce beauty and
tender strength
inspires us all

Life often hits us hard.
Routine and stress and
steady erosion shrink us.
Love is growth as
counterweight to life's
evil, but how to feed it?
This game is one for
couples that are not too
weary of a bit of playful
work and wish to level
up their marriage game.

Rule 1

Level up your marriage by talking about the topics on the cards and reaching a common answer. That's it, that is the game!

Rule 2

When talking about a topic, you only level-up when you reach an answer you are both happy with, and one that you both believe is useful to have articulated. You do not level up if you reach two different answers.

Rule 3

Every time you get to have a meaningful conversation about your relationship, congratulate yourselves. Take the card and stick it with some magnet to your fridge, as an achievement.

Rule 4

If you are struggling to pick topics, do it like this. Each pick a color (or the same color). Then draw 3 face-down cards each only from picked colors.

Rock-paper-scissors to decide who goes first. Then the first one picks a topic from their drawn topics.

Rule 5

You only level up if you do it constantly. Every month with no new talk resets your progress. We advice you set for yourself a recurring date, like the first and third Wed of every month.

Rule 6

The cards are kinda cool and you can also use them some other way. Actually, on one of the cards you will find a QR code to a lil piece of software that lets you create more cards that you can then print by following the instructions found at the same link.



Make your own cards.

[github.com/
olaruandreidan/XPCardGame](https://github.com/olaruandreidan/XPCardGame)

What does
our ideal
weekday
morning look
like, for both
of us?

How do we
want to
spend the
last twenty
minutes
before
sleep?

How do we
want to
handle the
laundry,
cooking, and
errands split
as our lives
get busier?

How do we
want to
handle
differing
sleep
schedules or
night-owl
versus
early-riser
habits?

What's our
rule of thumb
for big versus
small
purchases:
who decides,
and at what
price does it
become a
“we”
decision?

How do we
recover,
practically,
after a
short-tempered
moment at
home?

How do we
want to use a
“day off from
each other”
without it
turning into
avoidance?

What's our
rule for
screens,
gaming, or
scrolling
once we're
both home
for the
evening?

What should
we do when
one of us
brings home
a mood the
other didn't
sign up for?

What
differences in
our
temperaments
have quietly
turned out to
be good for us
rather than a
problem to
fix?

A household runs on a lot of invisible work, such as noticing the empty fridge, the overdue bill, remembering the friend who needs checking on, planning the weekend. How do we want to build that noticing together, rather than leaving the invisible burden mostly in one person's head?

What did
money mean
in the
household you
grew up in
and how does
that history
quietly shape
how you two
talk about
money now?

Who and how
decides the
priorities in the
work that you need
to get done
together, if fixing
the door creek is
more important
than going out or
doing groceries, if
cleaning the oven
and not selecting
the vacation
destination is how
we spend the
afternoon?

Who and how
decides the level
of quality that
needs to be
reached for
work you do
together, be it
laundry policy,
how clean the
fridge should be
or how to select
a present for
common friends?

How do we deal with a situation in which the other does something that we do not like, especially if we are in a social setting or under time pressure?

Children, such
a scary, yet
playful
concept. How
are we aligned
on this topic,
do we want
children, how
many, and
how would we
raise them?

How do we
want our
children
raised in
what we
believe and
value,
practically?

How do we
want to care
for our
parents as
they age?

How do you want to make big career or life decisions together going forward? If one of us gets a call toward a specific vocation or work, how far are we willing to bend our plans to support it?

Where do we
actually
want to be
living in ten
years?

What does retirement look like for us, and do we picture it the same way?

How do we
want to
handle it if
our incomes
end up very
unequal?

What's the
legacy (not
financial, the
actual
character or
values) we
want to
leave
behind?

What does a
“good
failure” look
like for us, a
risk we’d
respect each
other for
taking even
if it didn’t
work out?

How do we
want to keep
choosing
each other
on purpose,
decade after
decade,
rather than
by default?

If one of us can
access an
opportunity,
cushion, or
resource the other
can't, how can we
use that difference
in a way that feels
good to both of us,
rather than
something either
of us feels guilty
or resentful
about?

When our families' expectations for us don't match, which parts do we want to keep from each, which do we want to let go of, and what do we want to invent together that's entirely ours?

If we believe
the other one
is pouring
effort into a
goal that we
do not agree
with, how do
we
communicate
that and
resolve that
issue?

Where is one
of us
stronger than
the other,
and how do
we let that
carry us both
instead of
becoming a
source of
resentment?

What does
love as
sacrifice
actually cost
each of us
this season,
concretely?

What's a
compliment
or form of
affection you
wish I gave
more often?

How has the
other person
changed you
for the
better this
year?

What's a
small daily
habit of ours
that's quietly
good for the
marriage,
and that we
should
protect?

What does
being fully
present with
each other
actually
require us to
put down?

What's
something
you're proud
of that you
don't think
I've said out
loud
recently?

What does
taking up
something
hard
“together,”
rather than
each alone,
look like for
us right now?

What's one
thing about
how you love
that I should
learn to
receive
better?

What's a
version of "I
love you",
not the
words, but
an action,
that actually
means the
most to you?

Love can either use people up or genuinely empower them; what makes the difference is mutuality. Describe a recent moment that felt like real, mutual, empowering love. What specifically made it feel that way, and how could we create more moments like it?

Real closeness
doesn't come from
becoming the same
person; it comes
from staying
different and
choosing, again and
again, to
understand each
other across that
difference. What's a
difference between
us that you'd rather
protect and get
curious about than
smooth away?

If physical intimacy is something we're always learning together, what's one thing we'd want to get better at as a team?

What skills
does each one
of us want to
build in order
to be a better
partner and
how do you
plan on
empowering
each other in
this process?

How do we
actually want
to apologize
to each
other? What
makes an
apology land
instead of
just ending
the
argument?

What does
patience
actually look
like for us, in
practice, on
a bad day?

What's a
grudge
either of us
might still be
quietly
carrying, and
what would
it take to
actually let it
go?

What's
something I
do that
you've never
told me
actually
hurts?

How do we
want to
handle it
when we're
both right
and both
hurt?

How do we
make sure
the sun
doesn't go
down on an
unresolved
fight?

How do we
want to
handle
criticism
from each
other
without it
turning into
defense?

How do we
want to
handle it
when one of
us needs
comfort and
the other
jumps
straight to
fixing the
problem?

If the exact
situation that
caused our
worst fight
happened
again
tomorrow,
what would
each of us
actually do
differently
now?

Think about our
last real
disagreement.
What helped us
find the words
for what was
actually wrong?
How could we
practice that
together next
time, on
purpose?

Philosopher Ellie Anderson calls the work of figuring out what you're feeling, and helping your partner do the same, hermeneutic labor. Where does that kind of work already flow easily between us? Where would you like to build more of it, on purpose, together?

What often gets called someone's "intuition" in a relationship is really years of unacknowledged interpretive work, such as noticing, translating, and making sense. Is there a kind of understanding one of us seems to have "naturally"? What would it look like to treat that as a skill we're both building, rather than a trait only one of us has?

Describe a moment that felt more one-sided or draining than empowering. Without assigning blame, what would need to shift in either of us, or in how we relate, for a moment like that to feel mutual instead?

What's one
script about
how love or
partnership is
“supposed” to
work,
something you
inherited rather
than chose,
that you've had
to unlearn
together?

For Xhenis and Petru

With love,
Maria and Andrei



The marriage
level-up game